

states KERALA

■ By M.G. Radhakrishnan

K Venugopal had excellent credentials to be a front-ranking member of the Communist Party of India (Marxist) in Kerala. He is the nephew of late A.K. Gopalan, the legendary communist leader after whom most of the CPI(M) offices in India are named. He is the deputy general manager of *Desabhimani*, the half-a-million-plus circulation mouthpiece of the party, where he has been working for more than two decades. He has been a card-holding member for years and is known to be close to some of the top party leaders in the state.

Last Friday, the CPI(M) expelled Venugopal from the party. Though the terse one-line statement merely attributed his expulsion to "involvement in financial deals which brought ill-repute to the party", the incident is said to be a tip of an iceberg of corruption. Venugopal is seen as a benami for many top leaders of the party for whom corruption has become a way of life. The incident is threatening to prise open a can of worms that could tarnish the reputations of many big names in the state.



COMRADES IN SLEAZE

The expulsion of a senior CPI(M) member for taking Rs 1 crore as bribe for settling a deal threatens to open a can of worms that could tarnish the reputation of many party bigwigs



The issue has suddenly pumped adrenaline into the opposition United Democratic Front (UDF) which has been virtually comatose since its wipe-out in the assembly polls last year. "Venugopal is only a minion. The sleaze money has reached the CPI(M) top leadership. He has been made a scapegoat to save the skins of the top leaders," says Oommen Chandy, opposition leader.

The charge against Venugopal is that he took Rs 1 crore as bribe from LIS, a financial firm which has been facing investigation since 2005 for alleged embezzlement of funds. The money was allegedly taken by Venugopal who promised to freeze these investigations. The charges against LIS are related to acceptance of

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